Praise to the Deities of the Four Yogas

Yogacaturadevastotra · Toh 1170 · Derge Tengyur
སྣལ་བ་བཞི་ལེ་ལྟུང་བསྟོད་པ

The Praise to the Deities of the Four Yogas, in Sanskrit Yogacaturadevastotra and in Tibetan Jorwa Zhi Lha la Töpa, is a devotional hymn in verse that opens with homage to the Blessed Mother, the Perfection of Wisdom. It first praises the Buddha as he appears at the opening of the large Perfection of Wisdom sūtras, seated in the samādhi called the King of Samādhis and filling the worlds of the ten directions with light that makes beings certain of awakening, and then praises the bodhisattvas, arhats and lay disciples of his assembly. A second part honors the Perfection of Wisdom as the Mother of the buddhas of the three times and as the dharmakāya beyond all reference, and the hymn closes by celebrating the thirty-two major marks and eighty minor marks of a buddha's body, each linked to the virtuous deeds that produced it. Its colophon names the great paṇḍita Ratnakīrti as its author, and it is Toh 1170 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of praises (stotra).

In Sanskrit: Yogacaturadevastotranāma
In Tibetan: Praise to the Deities of the Four Yogas

Homage to the Blessed Mother, the Perfection of Wisdom.

Upon the lion throne, the seat set out,
With body upright and mind thoroughly settled,
Seated there in the vajra posture,
In the samādhi in which all samādhis are gathered,
The one called the King of Samādhis,
You rested in equipoise; then, mindful and fully aware,
You rose from it, and with your miraculous eye
Beheld the buddhafields: to you I bow.

From twenty-two places on your body
Rays of light, koṭis of niyutas,
Sixty hundred thousand of them from each place,
Stream forth: to that body, homage!

Throughout the Sahā world (this world of ours) and the worlds of the ten directions
You spread the radiance of your light,

And the sentient beings that light touched
Became certain of perfect awakening:
Homage to the Guide whose light streams forth!

The light of your body hairs and your natural radiance
Throughout the Sahā world and the worlds of the ten directions
Spread their brightness,
And the sentient beings that light touched
Became certain of perfect awakening:
Protector of beings, Śākyasiṃha (Lion of the Śākyas), to you I bow.

Hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of rays from your tongue:
From their tips spring lotuses of a thousand petals,
And upon those thousand sit sugatas (buddhas) endowed with enlightened mind,
Who journey to the fields of the ten directions
And teach the Dharma of the six perfections;
The sentient beings who hear that Dharma are certain of awakening:
I praise the emanation body of the Protector of beings.

Through the samādhi of the Lion's Liberation,
Through the eighteen great portents of quaking and swaying,
All the lower realms of the Sahā world and the ten directions
You cut off, and gave their beings the fortune of gods and humans;
Remembering their former lives, they bow to the Buddha:
To you who rescue from the lower realms, I bow in homage.

The world systems of the Sahā world and the ten directions
You outshine with your light; brilliant
And radiant you sit: that body I praise.

Your natural body steadfast, the gods
Made offerings of offering substances, and above your head,
Through your blessing, the flowers became a mansion of many stories.
Your own light illumines all the fields
Of the Sahā world and the ten directions; and the sentient beings who see you
Think, 'He sits right before me, teaching the Dharma':
I praise the one body that appears as many.

Your own light pervading the fields of the ten directions,
To all the sentient beings dwelling there

You appear together with your retinue:
Śākyasiṃha of golden light, to you I bow.

You who have fully attained dhāraṇīs and samādhis,
Whose domain is emptiness and signlessness,
Who are endowed with aspirations free of conceptual construction,
Who have fully gained retention and patient acceptance of the sameness of phenomena:
Bodhisattvas of great mind, to you I pay homage and praise.

Endowed with unobstructed eloquence, your teaching
Is inexhaustible, and you have fully mastered
The analytical knowledges;
You sport in the great superknowledges,
Your superknowledges undiminished: to you I pay homage and praise.

Sweet and pleasing in speech, free of laziness,
Diligent, with no regard for body or life,
Free of pretense, flattery and love of fame,
Since you have no thought for gain or honor,
You teach the Dharma free of material motive;
You have realized the sublime patient acceptance of the profound Dharma:
You who have attained fearlessness, to you I pay homage and praise.

Undaunted, you have passed beyond the deeds of Māra;
You have vanquished your adversaries, karma and afflictions;
You are not overpowered by hostile opponents;
Hard for śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas to fathom,
The stream of your karmic obscurations is cut: to you I pay homage and praise.

Skilled in discerning and in teaching,
Your aspirations reckoned over countless eons,
The first to smile, with no angry frown,
Endowed with pleasant and gentle speech:
To you who fully realize the Dharma, homage!

Skilled in chanting verses to others,
Your eloquence unbroken, you possess the fearlessness
That overwhelms boundless assemblies;
Through endless koṭis of eons

Skilled in bringing forth teaching and wisdom: you I praise.

Phenomena you understand as illusions, mirages,
The moon in water, dreams, echoes,
Visual apparitions, space, cities of gandharvas,
Emanations and reflections;
To you whose minds are undaunted, I pay homage and praise.

Your knowledge of the workings of sentient beings' minds is subtle;
Skilled in conduct, you are skilled in penetrating it;
Without hostility, vast in patience, you realize the sameness of phenomena;
Possessing the profound Dharma, your depths are hard to fathom;
Having gained mastery over mind and phenomena, you deliver from karma, afflictions,
Views and obscurations: to you I pay homage and praise.

Skilled in teaching the realization of dependence,
You know and have entered the inexhaustible way of dependent arising;
You have abandoned views, latent tendencies and fetters;
Skilled in stilling karma and afflictions,
You are free of their outbursts: to you, homage!

Having fully realized the truths, skilled in wisdom,
You are convinced that phenomena are like echoes;
Your teaching of the Dharma is boundless, and you are free of fear;
You are skilled in understanding the self just as it is;
Contemplating the realms, you hold them to be dreams;
You who recollect countless buddhas, I praise.

Skilled in drawing near wherever buddhas appear,
Skilled in making requests of countless buddhas,
Skilled in stilling the views and afflictions of the mind,
You accomplish hundreds of thousands of samādhis;
Sporting in them, you realize wisdom: you I praise.

Bhadrapāla, Ratnākara and the rest:
Your qualities, though one were to tell them
Without end for eons, could never be told in full;
The assembly of bodhisattvas such as these I praise.

Arhats, taints exhausted, free of afflictions,
Having gained mastery, minds fully liberated,
Wisdom thoroughly liberated,
Thoroughbreds, great elephants, who have done what was to be done,
Who have done their work and laid down the burden,
Who have fully attained their own aim,
Whose fetters of existence are wholly exhausted,
Whose minds, through the perfect word,
Are thoroughly liberated,
Who have attained the supreme perfection of mastery over mind:
The assembly of śrāvaka monks I praise.

Laymen and laywomen,
The assembly of those who have seen the Dharma, I praise.

Praise to the Deities of the Dharmakāya Maṇḍala

Perfection of Wisdom, beyond speech, thought and expression,
Unborn, unceasing, whose essential nature is space,
The domain of the primordial wisdom of individual self-awareness:
Mother of the Victors of the three times, to you I pay homage and praise.

On the trunk of the Dharma, the eighteen emptinesses,
Adorned with the lovely ornaments of the ten perfections,
Lush with the foliage of the four immeasurables,
The fruits of non-arising and non-ceasing ripen one by one:
To the dharmakāya of the ten grounds, homage!

In all the realms, upon ground of gold,
Jewels of many kinds are spread as paving,
And puṇḍarīka flowers fall like rain:
Virtuous Lady, you who became the Mother, to you I pay homage and praise.

Without location, just like space,
Free of conceptual elaboration and without appearance,
Your mind is like space,
Space that has no edge and no center;
It is the nature of reality (dharmatā) of the buddhas,
Utterly beyond the three times:
Dharmakāya beyond all reference, to you I pay homage and praise.

Having welcomed and escorted your teachers, praised the Dharma in sweet words,
Built temples and stūpas,
And offered the first portions, your hands and feet are marked with wheels:
You of the vast retinue, to you I pay homage and praise.

Since your commitments were firm, your feet are firmly planted:
To you, unshakable and steadfast, homage!

Since you cultivated the four means of gathering disciples,
Your hands and both your feet are joined by webs:
Homage to this omen of disciples swiftly gathering!

As a sign that you gave delicious food and drink,
Your hands and feet are soft, their flesh tender and young,
And seven parts of your body are full and prominent:
Bowing, I praise this omen of well-being.

Through virtues such as giving up the taking of life,
Your heels are broad, your body large and straight:
You whose body is great and tall, I praise.

Because you took up the accumulation of virtue and the like,
Your insteps are high and your body hairs curl upward:
Homage to this omen of the unequaled Dharma!

Through the sciences and crafts, service, gifts to others and the like,
Your calves are like those of the ena antelope:
Homage to this omen of swift understanding!

Because you gave away everything you owned,
Your hands reach down over your thighs:
Homage to this omen of taming!

Through virtues such as the celibate life,
Your private parts are withdrawn into a sheath:
Homage to this omen of many sons!

Because you gave seats, palaces and the like,
Your color is golden and your complexion smooth:
You who obtain fine dwellings and the like, homage!

Having served your masters and others,
The rows of hair on your body curl to the right, and you are adorned with the

ūrṇā, the curl between your brows:
Homage to this omen of equality!

Through virtues such as never using unpleasant words,
Your upper body is a lion's, your round eyes beautiful:
Homage to this omen of invincibility!

You gave medicine and the like to the sick:
Your fingers are full, and you have the supreme sense of taste:
You who bear the omen of little sickness, I praise.

Because you set up food stands and the like,
Your height and breadth are in proportion, and you bear the crown protuberance (uṣṇīṣa):
Homage to you who hold great dominion!

For a long time you spoke pleasing and agreeable words:
Your tongue is nimble and thin, your voice the voice of Brahmā:
You whose speech has five aspects, I praise.

Having long abandoned idle talk,
Your jaw is like a lion's:
Homage to this omen of even speech!

Through peerless service and a pure livelihood,
Your teeth are even and very white:
You bear the omen of a retinue gathered long before.
Through words that are true and free of slander,
Your teeth are finely set, a full forty in number:
You whose retinue cannot be divided, I praise.

Because your gaze was free of attachment and anger,
Your lashes, and the white and black of your eyes, are clearly distinct:
Bearing the omen of beauty in every way,
You who possess the thirty-two major marks, I praise.

Secluded from the bustle, your nails are the color of copper;
Intent on benefiting sentient beings, your nails are glossy in hue;
Because your lineage is high, your nails are raised;
Your fingers are rounded, and you are free of fault;
Your store of virtue complete, your nails are full;
Your roots of virtue accomplished, your fingers taper;
Secluded in your way of life, your veins do not show;

The knots of affliction untied, your veins have no knots;
Your ankles do not show, and you possess the Dharma of seclusion;
Because you deliver from what is uneven, your countenance is even.

Lion of lions, I praise you who walk with a lion's gait;
Elephant, I praise you who walk with an elephant's gait;
Serene one, I praise you who move with a swan's stride;
Lordly bull, I praise you who walk with a lordly bull's gait.

In harmony with the five paths, you walk turning to the right;
Beautiful to behold, you walk in beauty: you I praise.

Your mind free of wavering, you walk without wavering;
Your body is excellent, showing forth good qualities;
Your body cleansed, your wrongdoing cleansed away;
You who teach the Dharma, your body tapering in due order: you I praise.

Pure in body, speech and mind, your body is soft;
Possessing a perfectly pure body, your body is perfectly pure;
Because your Dharma and discipline are beautiful, your requisites are complete;
Your qualities vast and excellent, your body is large and beautiful;
Possessing an even mind, your body is even: you I praise.

Teaching the gentle Dharma, your body is youthful;
Possessing an undaunted mind, your body never shrinks;
Because you abandoned nonvirtue, your body is wholly victorious;
Your becoming exhausted, your body is firm: you I praise.

Your limbs are wholly beautiful, your vision pure;
Through having vanquished pride and the like,
Your belly is round, your belly smooth, your belly does not sag;
Because you have truly averted the waning of the Dharma,
Your belly lies flat: you I praise.

Having fathomed the profound Dharma, your qualities complete,
Your navel is deep, your navel coiling to the right;
Through virtues such as a beautiful retinue,
You are beautiful and pure, and on your body there are no moles;
Through virtues such as gentleness and loving-kindness,
Your hands are soft, and the lines of your palms deep and glossy;

Through virtues such as craft and learning,
The lines of your palms are long, and your face is not too long:
You in whom arising forms appear as reflections, I praise.

With gentleness foremost and your qualities complete,
Your tongue is soft, your tongue thin, your tongue red;
Without timidity, your qualities complete,
Your speech is majestic, like the great elephant's call and like thunder;
Through virtues such as having passed beyond the fetters of existence,
Your canine teeth are round and sharp:
You whose teeth are even and taper in due order, I praise.

Through dwelling on the mountain of wisdom and the like,
To you whose nose is high and clean, I bow.

Your vision perfectly pure, your qualities complete,
Your eyes are long, and the lashes of your eyes are thick;
Your brows are soft and long, the white and the black distinct;
Your brows are glossy and even: you I praise.

Your supreme Dharma vast, meaningful and complete,
Your ears are long, your ears are soft, your hearing unimpaired;
Through overcoming Māra and other hostile opponents,
Your forehead is broad, your forehead well formed;
As a sign that your aspirations are utterly fulfilled,
Your head is full, and the hair of your head, like bees,
Is black: to you I pay homage and praise.

Gentle in mind, you never speak harshly, free of rough speech;
Through having abandoned the latent tendencies abandoned through meditation, and the like,
Your hair is thick, your hair is soft, your hair is not matted,
Fragrant, your hair not rough: you I praise.

Your hands and feet bear the śrīvatsa and the auspicious swirl;
Adorned with the eighty excellent minor marks,
To you I pay homage and praise.

The Praise to the Deities of the Four Yogas, composed by the great paṇḍita Ratnakīrti, is complete. Translated by the Nepalese Mahāpana himself.

Translator's Notes

• These verses follow the opening scene of the large Perfection of Wisdom sūtras: the Buddha's samādhi, the light from his body, pores and tongue, the shaking of the worlds, the gods' mansion of flowers, and the assemblies of bodhisattvas, arhats and lay disciples. The second section praises the Mother and the dharmakāya and then begins on the major marks and their causes.

Evident copyists' slips are read as follows: stan ("seat") for sten in the obscure opening words sten mtshon, rendered "the seat set out"; gzhag ("settled") for gzhan in "mind thoroughly settled"; mi mjed (the Sahā world) for mi mdzad; rtog med ("free of conceptual construction", matching the sūtra's akalpita) for rdol med; and brtan pas ("since your commitments were firm") for brtan g.yas.

The samādhi is named as the text has it, the Lion's Liberation (seng ge rnam grol); in the sūtra the corresponding samādhi is the Lion's Play (siṃhavikrīḍita), and rnam grol may be a slip for rnam rol.

In "natural radiance" and "natural body", rang bzhin renders Sanskrit prakṛti, not the philosophical svabhāva.

• This piece praises the thirty-two major marks, each with its karmic cause and the omen it portends, then the eighty minor marks, and ends with the colophon. Where this text's marks differ from the standard lists (round eyes, full fingers, an even countenance, hands reaching over the thighs), they are given as this text has them.

In the stanzas on the teeth, 'khor ba is the retinue ('khor), as the omen of an indivisible retinue shows, not saṃsāra.

Evident copyists' slips are read as follows: drang ba ("straight") for drar ba; chu zheng ("height and breadth") for chu zhing; mi sdang ("without anger") for mi ldan; dben chos ("the Dharma of seclusion") for dbyen chos ("discord"); phyal ("belly") for khyal; snyan ("hearing") for snyam. In the line on gentle speech, mi gsung is written twice and is read once.

The syllable de'u after "pride" is unclear and is left untranslated. Sku che ring ba is kept as "body great and tall", though sku tshe ring ba, "long-lived", the traditional fruit of not killing, may be intended; likewise dang pa ("serene one") may stand for ngang pa ("swan"), as the neighboring lines on the lion, elephant and bull suggest.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.